FZ1073: Who Vets the Pilot?

A pilot with an axe, a minister pointing at the Mossad, and the oldest excuse in the Torah. Israel's gate needs one named guard.

By Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren · Published 7 October 2026 · updated 9 October 2026

On the morning of 30 September, flydubai flight FZ1073 was on its way from Dubai to Ben Gurion when the co-pilot turned on his captain. According to Emirati investigators, he struck Captain Smit Machchhar with the cockpit crash axe and tried to take the controls. The captain, wounded and losing his vision, got the cockpit door open. The attacker shut it. He opened it again. Passengers and crew poured in, pinned the man down, and off-duty pilots brought the aircraft down safely at Tabuk in Saudi Arabia. About 174 passengers were aboard, most of them Israeli.[1][2][3]

“I had that one last fight in me and gave it my all,” the captain later recalled.[2] Israel was right to celebrate him and the passengers who rushed that door.

But celebrating the rescue does not answer the question it raises: who was supposed to check the man in the right-hand seat?

What we now know

The co-pilot has been identified in Reuters and AP reporting as Hamam al-Hammami, an Omani national.[1][4] AP reports that officials say Oman had barred him from flying over concerns that he had adopted extremist views. The Emirati-led investigation reportedly found that he had sought work with an airline flying to Israel specifically to carry out an attack, and had first planned it for July.[4] Reuters and the Times of Israel report that investigators believe he meant to crash the aircraft at Ben Gurion itself.[5][6]

As far as the public record shows, this was not missed because the system was blinded. It was missed because no part of the system was looking.

Israeli law requires airlines to send passenger and crew details, including names and nationalities, up to 48 hours before a flight. AP reports that the list for this flight was shared ahead of time and raised no flags.[4] The crew list went to the national passenger-data centre under the Tax Authority, which passes information on to the security agencies. Its work, Ynet notes, is aimed mainly at criminals and money laundering, not terror.[7][8]

Then the questions began, and the answers went around in a circle.

The circle

Speaking to Kan, Transportation Minister Miri Regev said intelligence questions are split between the Mossad and the Shin Bet: “The Shin Bet is responsible for Israeli flights, and the Mossad is responsible for foreign companies. Flydubai is a foreign company.” The list, she said, “did not come to us, because the body that is supposed to identify the crew is an intelligence body. We are not an intelligence body.”[8]

AP reports that the Shin Bet says the Transportation Ministry is responsible for vetting lists from foreign flights.[4] Ynet reports that the Mossad says checking this is not its job.[9] The head

of the Civil Aviation Authority, Shmuel Zakai, said that under a government decision his authority has "no responsibility whatsoever for security matters. We are responsible for safety."[8]

The ministry's own security division put it most frankly. "We are not an intelligence body that checks the intelligence background of foreigners," a representative said. "We have no forces abroad. We have no staff that checks every person there." The division said it relies on the airlines' own declarations that their pilots have been checked, and that it could not say how many pilots from hostile states have landed in Israel.[6][9] A senior official in the division added: "We have 120 airlines flying here."[8]

Put those statements side by side and you get a map with no one standing on it. The minister points to the Mossad. The Shin Bet points to the ministry. The Mossad points away. The aviation authority says security is somebody else's department. The security division says it is not an intelligence service. And the foreign airline, which signed the declaration, is the one party that cannot be held to account by an Israeli voter.

This is not one person's failure. According to Army Radio, as reported by the Jerusalem Post, the Shin Bet stepped back from securing foreign flights in 2021 and the ministry did not take up the task. A classified state comptroller report flagged the issue in May 2024, and in mid-2025 the Prime Minister formally assigned foreign-flight security to the ministry's security division, over the objections of officials there who said they lacked the tools, authority and budget.[8][10]

One more detail should trouble anyone who cares about clean lines of responsibility. Channel 12 reported, and the Times of Israel, Ynet, the Jerusalem Post and Israel Hayom relayed, that the director of the ministry's Aviation Security Operations Center, who works for the ministry as an outside contractor, has also done paid private training and consulting for flydubai and Emirates, carriers his office oversees. The ministry says his outside work was approved and done outside his ministry hours.[11][12] Whatever the rules allowed, the person who checks the gate should not be paid by the people coming through it.

"The woman You gave me"

We have just begun the Torah again, and Parashat Bereishit already contains this whole story.

When G-d asks Adam whether he has eaten from the tree, Adam does not say "I did." He says: "The woman whom You gave to be with me, she gave me of the tree, and I ate" (Bereishit 3:12). In one verse he blames his wife and, by implication, his Creator. Chava, asked in turn, says: "The serpent beguiled me" (3:13). Nobody in the garden says "I." The first failure of human responsibility is not the eating; it is the answer afterwards.

The parasha gives us the other side too. Adam was placed in the garden "to work it and to guard it," le'ovdah u'leshomrah (2:15). Guarding was part of the job from the first day. And when the gate of Eden is finally closed, the Torah does not leave it to chance: G-d places the cherubim and the flaming, turning sword "to guard the way to the Tree of Life," lishmor et derech etz ha-chayim (3:24). The way in has a named guard. That is the image a state should keep in view.

A chapter later Kayin asks the buck-passer's question: "Am I my brother's keeper?" (4:9). It is the same root, shomer. The Torah's answer is yes. You are.

A shomer in halachah is not a vague well-wisher. The categories of guardians in Mishpatim are precise: who took what upon himself, for pay or for free, and what he answers for when something goes wrong. Responsibility in the Torah is assigned before the loss, not argued about after it. The flaw exposed by FZ1073 is that Israel's gate had many people standing near it and no one who had taken the role of shomer upon himself.

A gap that can be closed

The good news is that this is fixable, and the fix does not need secret methods discussed in public. It needs clear ownership.

International rules already show where the gap sits. Under Article 33 of the Chicago Convention, states recognise the pilot licences issued by an aircraft's state of registry, provided they meet ICAO minimum standards.[13] A licence certifies that a pilot can fly. It says nothing about whether a pilot can be trusted with a planeload of Israelis on approach to Ben Gurion. Zakai put the working rule plainly: "the country from which the aircraft departs is responsible for security."[8] For a country with Israel's enemies, that is not enough.

Four steps follow.

First, one owner. The government should name, by decision and in writing, a single body accountable for confirming that every crew member on every foreign flight into Israel has been checked to an Israeli standard, with the budget and intelligence access to do it. If that is the Transportation Ministry, give it the tools. If it is a security agency, say so. What cannot continue is a duty that belongs to everyone and therefore to no one.

Second, the lists must be read for the right question. Israel already receives crew names in advance. Those names should be checked for security risk, not only for crime and money laundering, and the result should reach the body that grants landing permission.

Third, test the declarations. A foreign carrier's statement that its pilots were vetted should be a condition, backed by information-sharing with the state of the operator, and not the end of the inquiry. This case shows the risk: AP reports that officials say Oman had already barred this man from flying.[4]

Fourth, clean hands at the gate. No official who approves foreign carriers should take paid work from those carriers, whatever the employment arrangement.

The Prime Minister has asked the head of the National Security Council to appoint an examiner to review all security aspects of foreign civil aviation to Israel.[8][4] That is a start, but the Jerusalem Post reports that the review will have no direct power to change policy.[8] Opposition leaders Gadi Eisenkot and Naftali Bennett have called for Regev's dismissal.[14][4] Voters will weigh that three weeks from now, in the election on 27 October.[4] But a resignation, or a refusal to resign, does not by itself put anyone at the gate.

On Iran, and on restraint

President Trump has said he personally believes Iran was behind the attack: "I do. I personally do."[15][5] He may prove right. But according to the Times of Israel, Vice President Vance said he had seen nothing conclusive, Israeli security officials have so far assessed that the attacker acted alone, and the Prime Minister has said it is too early to know.[15][5] Whoever sent him, or

whether anyone did, the gap was ours. A hostile service only exploits a door; it does not build it. If the investigation leads to Tehran, the question of who was meant to check becomes sharper, not softer.

The answer Adam did not give

The Torah's first story of failure is also its first lesson in how to answer it. G-d asks Adam, "Ayeka," where are you? (3:9). It is not a request for a location. It is an invitation to stand where you are and say what you did.

Israel's leaders were handed that question on 30 September by an injured captain and a cabin of ordinary people who did not stop to ask whose job it was. They ran to the door. The least the state can do is decide, in writing and before the next flight, whose job it is to guard the way.

The cherubim did not ask who sent them. They knew what they were guarding.

Update, 9 Oct 2026: On 8 October, at the President's Residence in Jerusalem, President Isaac Herzog presented the Presidential Award for Civilian Heroism to six civilians from FZ1073: Tali and Zvika Manes, Yaniv Hayun, Asaf Rajuan, Or Pardilov and Dr Shota Musayev. He said he intends to honour Captain Smit Machchhar with the same award, as the committee recommended, once he has recovered. Herzog also said their bravery "cannot absolve us of the obligation to obtain full answers." The question of who vets the pilot is still open.[16]

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